of the six vaults were known but not those of the remaining two, labelled Vaults A and B, which had remained closed since the 1930s. Following objections made by the temple authorities a divining service was conducted to determine the will of Lord Vishnu. This revealed that if Vault B was opened it would provoke divine displeasure and bring bad luck to Kerala, so it was decided that Vault B should remain closed for the time being, but that Vault A could be opened. This duly took place in July 2011.

No official inventory has yet been published, but a combination of off-the-record briefings and determined digging by journalists has since revealed treasure on a scale that has made headlines all round the world, seemingly confirming the temple's reputed status as the richest in the world. The contents are said to include a 1-metre-tall solid gold statue of Vishnu; a 5.5-metre-long gold chain; a 500-kilogram gold sheaf; a gold veil weighing 36 kilograms; a sixteen-part gold *anki* or ceremonial costume weighing almost 30 kilograms; a giant gold throne, studded with diamonds and precious stones; at least three gold crowns similarly studded with precious stones; hundreds of gold chairs; thousands of gold pots and jars; 1200 chains of gold-coins; gold coconut shells studded with precious stones; several sackfuls of gold artefacts, necklaces and diadems, as well as diamonds, rubies, sapphires, emeralds and other gemstones; several Napoleonic-era gold coins; and an 800-kilogram (1800 lb) hoard of gold coins that include Greek and Roman examples dating from 100 BCE onwards.[18]

Vault B remains unopened, but if an unofficial inventory made for the Travancore royal family back in 1931 is accurate, this is as full of treasure as Vault A. There are also rumours that two more vaults, G and H, have been located. In the meantime, arguments rage both in the papers and in the law courts as to who has a legal right to all this wealth: